Journal of English for Academic Purposes 51 (2021) 100983

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Journal of English for Academic Purposes

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/jeap

Researching EAP Practice

Applying local grammars in EAP teaching

Lei Zhang [a], Hang Su [b, *]

[a] Anhui University of Finance and Economics, PR China
[b] Sichuan International Studies University, PR China

ARTICLE INFO

Article history:
Received 27 November 2020
Received in revised form 25 February 2021
Accepted 28 February 2021
Available online 8 March 2021

Keywords:
Local grammars
Discourse acts
EAP teaching
Academic writing

ABSTRACT

Local grammars have been reported to have the potential to facilitate English language teaching. This study explores this potential by applying local grammars into the teaching of discourse acts that are frequently performed in academic writing. For demonstration, the study focuses on the teaching of one particular discourse act, i.e., exemplification, and argues that the teaching procedure presented in this paper can also be applied to the teaching of other discourse acts in academic writing. The study shows that local grammars can be integrated into classroom activities, which would in turn help improve EFL learners' pragmatic performance in academic writing.

© 2021 Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.

1. Introduction

Previous studies have shown that there are a number of discourse acts, referring to communicative functions such as defining, exemplifying etc., that are frequently performed in academic writing (e.g., Su & Zhang, 2020). At the same time, many other studies have found that English as a Foreign Language (EFL) learners often have difficulty performing such acts appropriately in writing tasks. Hinkel (2004, p. 297), for example, observes that "[a]lthough giving examples represents a prevalent explanatory and thesis support strategy in constructing persuasive text in English, teachers and researchers have found that college-level L2 writers rarely employ this strategy successfully and in accordance with the guidelines identified in L2 composition instruction". Limberg (2015, p. 276) similarly notes that EFL learners are in need of a repertoire of language resources for performing appropriately such discourse acts. This points to the significance of teaching discourse acts in English for Academic Purposes (EAP) pedagogy, which is also consistent with the current trend in corpus-based EAP genre research that emphasizes the analysis of form-function mappings in the teaching of rhetoric moves and steps in academic writing (e.g., Lu, Yoon, & Kisselev, 2021; Moreno & Swales, 2018).

In this paper we propose a local grammar approach to the teaching of such discourse acts in EAP contexts. Briefly, local grammar is an approach to language description that seeks to describe the lexical-grammatical realizations of one target communicative function or discourse act (see also Hunston, 2002, pp. 167–183; Hunston & Su, 2019). What distinguishes local grammars from general grammars is that the relationship between syntactic units is accounted for in functional-pragmatic terms (e.g. 'Exemplified' and 'Exemplification' were used in the local grammar analyses of exemplification; see Section 2) rather than in traditional grammatical terms such as Subject, Object, etc. (see Su and Zhang (2020) for more discussion). Previous studies have employed the local grammar approach to account for discourse acts such as evaluation

* Corresponding author. Bowen Building, Room 2–1, Research Centre for Foreign Languages and Literature, Sichuan International Studies University, 33 Zhuanzhi Road, Shapingba District, Chongqing, 400031 , PR China
E-mail addresses: zhangleiaufe@126.com (L. Zhang), suhangunique@hotmail.com (H. Su).

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2021.100983
1475-1585/© 2021 Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.

(Hunston & Sinclair, 2000, pp. 74–101; Hunston & Su, 2019) and exemplification (Su & Zhang, 2020), which shows that local grammars can provide a more systematic and specialized description of the target functions. Studies have also argued that such description would have pedagogical implications (e.g., Su, 2020; Su & Zhang, 2020; Hunston & Su, 2019). For instance, each local grammar offers an inventory of lexical-grammatical resources that can be used to perform one specific function, and also provides quantitative information (e.g., frequency) for each semantic pattern, suggesting the typicality of each pattern. However, despite the acknowledgement of the pedagogical value of local grammars, few attempts have been made to investigate how local grammars can in practice be applied in English language teaching, let alone the teaching of specific discourse acts in academic writing (cf. Su & Zhang, 2020).

Therefore, this study attempts to bridge this gap by exploring the pedagogical applications of local grammars in EAP contexts. It proposes a local grammar approach to the teaching of discourse acts in academic writing, which is demonstrated with the instruction of exemplification to Chinese EFL learners. It is further argued that the teaching procedure outlined in the present study can also be applied to the teaching of various discourse acts in academic writing.

2. A local grammar approach to the teaching of discourse acts in academic writing: the case of 'exemplification'

This section discusses the pedagogical practice of applying local grammars in the teaching of discourse acts in academic writing, using exemplification as an example. Following Su and Zhang (2020), exemplification is defined here as a discourse act that is performed by the writer him/herself to illustrate an argument/viewpoint by citing relevant studies or to exemplify a superordinate category by presenting subordinate ones. We focus on this specific discourse act because it is a recurrent feature of academic writing and plays an important role to enhance the accessibility and credibility of findings and arguments (Hyland, 2007).

2.1. Participants

The research context for the present investigation is an EAP course in which students were expected to learn the basic skills for academic writing. This one-semester course involved four classes, with 115 third year English major students taking part in. The course was instructed by one of the authors who had more than ten years' English language teaching experiences.

2.2. Corpus

The corpus used in this course is our self-constructed corpus of research articles of Linguistics. It includes 133 research articles published between the year 2013–2015 in ten top-ranking journals of Linguistics such as *Journal of English for Academic Purposes*, *English for Specific Purposes* and *Journal of Neurolinguistics*, amounting to 947,964 tokens. In each journal, eight to fifteen research articles written by English L1 users (judged by their names and affiliations) were randomly collected. The corpus software used is AntConc (Version 3.4.3; http://www.laurenceanthony.net/software.html).

2.3. Overview of the teaching program

In the course, various discourse acts such as "exemplifying", "defining", "comparing and contrasting", etc., were introduced and explained. The overall teaching procedure is shown in Fig. 1.

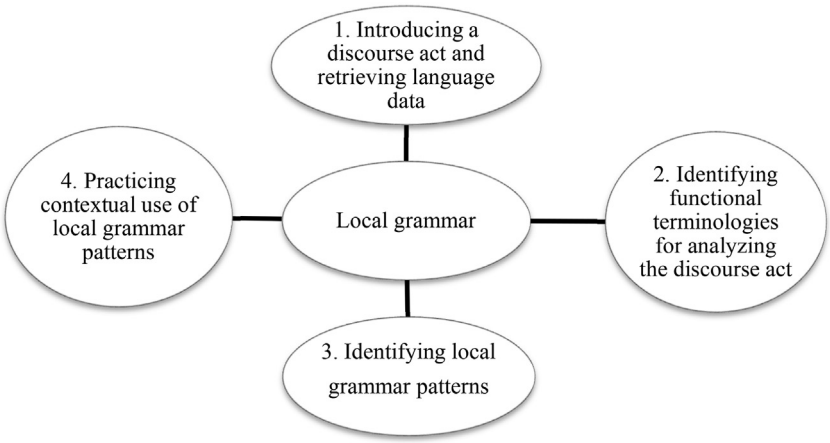

Fig. 1. The design of the teaching procedure.

As shown in Fig. 1, the teaching process includes four major steps, all of which draw on insights from local grammars. Specifically, students were firstly guided to observe the real language data of exemplification by searching "markers of exemplification" such as *for example*, *e.g.*, and *illustrate* in the corpus. In the second step, students were instructed to do some preliminary analyses and identify functional-pragmatic local grammar terminologies (e.g., 'Exemplified', 'Exemplification') that could be useful for analyzing exemplification. In the third stage, the teacher demonstrated how instances of exemplification in the corpus could be analyzed from a local grammar perspective and how local grammar patterns can be identified. Finally, students were instructed to choose appropriate local grammar patterns of exemplification in different contexts by doing some exercises. All student-teacher interactions, especially students' reaction to each step and the teacher's subsequent feedback were manually documented after each class by the teacher. The four steps are illustrated in more detail below.

2.4. Step 1: Introducing a discourse act with authentic instances

2.4.1. Teaching content

The first step of the teaching practice is to expose students to authentic instances of exemplification in academic writing. To be specific, students were first informed of the typical exemplificatory markers (e.g. *for example*, *e.g.*, *exemplify*, etc.), and these markers were then searched in the corpus to retrieve instances of exemplification. The teacher subsequently presented the concordances to students, as shown in Concordance Sample 1.

Concordance Sample 1 Concordances of *for example*, *for instance*, *an example of*, *e.g.* and *illustrate*

activities. The sum of answers ranges from 0 to 12. **For example**, "When I have learned a new and intere

Lindblom (1963b) and Stevens & House (1963)). **For example**, Broad and Fertig (1970) showed that i

with student writers. Burrough-Boenisch (2003a), **for instance**, argues that proofreaders who share t

Klaassen, 2001, pp. 177–179). Wilkinson (2005b), **for instance**, argues that institutions adopting En

than their own knowledge. The following quote is **an example of** the latter: Thinking about referenci

he issues discussed in Interview 3. Appendix 1 is **an example of** the outcome of these cyclical analyt

onological influence on L2 word-form acquisition (**e.g.**, [Hamada and Koda, 2008], [Feldman and Healy, and assume the existence of a specific addressee (**e.g.**, using imperative constructions; see Swales, g periods for each group. Both Table 1 and Fig. 1 **illustrate** that although the three groups were ver

on sections in both languages. The examples below **illustrate** how writers in both languages use the

Instances of each exemplificatory marker were shown following the order of its frequency and students were encouraged to group the instances according to their structural similarity. For example, in Concordance Sample 1, Burrough-Boenisch (2003a)*, for instance, argues that* … and Wilkinson (2005b)*, for instance, argues that* were supposed to be put in the same structural group as they share the same structural pattern $\mathbf{N_{human}}$ **for instance, V that** (Table 1). Similarly, *The following quote is an example of the latter* … and *Appendix 1 is an example of the outcome of these* … were grouped into the pattern **N v-link an example of N** (Table 2). This helps to raise students' phraseological awareness of exemplifying language, reminding them of the routinized structures of exemplification in academic writing.

2.4.2. Students' reaction and teacher's response

In the classroom practice, most students showed strong interest in corpus-assisted language learning and recognized the value of corpus investigation. At the same time, they also raised some questions including: 1) the source of language data (e.g., *Where did you find the texts?*), 2) the usage of concordancing software (e.g., *How can you put these instances into such an ordered sequence?*), 3) the coverage of the texts (e.g., *Can these instances cover all the realizations of exemplification?*), 4) register difference (e.g., *Are these exemplifying expressions different from those in our daily conversation?*). All the questions were dealt with in the classroom through, for example, the introduction of the research corpus, the detailed explanation and demonstration of the use of the concordancing software (i.e., AntConc), etc. As it was observed that the structural grouping of language instances was challenging to undergraduate students, the teacher and students worked together to figure out the structural groups and eventually reached an agreement on the grouping.

2.5. Step 2: Identifying functional terminologies for analyzing the discourse act

2.5.1. Teaching content

Provided all the instances of exemplification were analyzed in terms of structural similarity in step 1, students were further instructed to analyze them from a local grammar perspective. For example, for instances in which *illustrate* occurs in the

Table 1
Structural analysis of instances of exemplification 1.

N_{human}	for instance,	V	That
Burrough-Boenisch (2003a),	for instance,	argues	that proofreaders who share …
Wilkinson (2005b),	for instance,	argues	that institutions adopting …

Table 2
Structural analysis of instances of exemplification 2.

N	v-link	an example of	N
The following quote	Is	an example of	the latter …
Appendix 1	Is	an example of	the outcome of these …

structural pattern **N illustrate N** (see Concordance Sample 2), students were first guided to pay attention to the noun phrases that occur on the left of the node word illustrate, such as The Oapan words in (3) and (4) and Fig. 1. The teacher instructed students to recognize the common meaning of these noun phrases as "the concrete information used to exemplify", which can be labelled 'Exemplification', i.e., the elements illustrating an argument, viewpoint or a superordinate category. Next, students' attention was drawn to the noun phrases occurring on the right of the node word, such as the operationalisation of …, and the normal airway structure …. As these noun phrases express the meaning of "the thing that is being exemplified", they were labelled 'Exemplified'.

Concordance Sample 2 Concordances of illustrate

en lost in Oapan. The Oapan words in (3) and (4) **illustrate** the postulated development of a high tone

ntextualisation, embedding and mapping. Table 3 **illustrates** the operationalisation of the framewor

new structure of macro- and micro-points. Fig. 2 **illustrates** the difference in structure building b

f the model, including the MATLAB code). Fig. 1 **illustrates** the normal airway structure down to ab

l excerpts were counted. The following examples **illustrate** the different types of attempted paraph.

Overall, this step leads to the identification of nine terminologies that have been shown to be useful for a local grammar analysis of exemplification (see also Su & Zhang, 2020). These terms are listed and succinctly explained in Table 3.

As shown in Table 3, for example, in the instance The activity is also an example of a team (or joint) activity, the subject The activity indicates the 'thing' being used to illustrate, hence labelled 'Exemplification'. This step is important as it helps students to understand the various functional terminologies associated with exemplification.

2.5.2. Students' reaction and teacher's response

It has to be noted that this step was rather challenging as it requires students' cognitive processing of the semantic relationships between different syntactic elements of each instance. However, this is useful in that it familiarized students with the local grammar analysis and such that they could work on analyzing independently other discourse acts from a local grammar perspective, which would further help raise students' awareness of the phraseological tendency of language in use at the discourse-semantic level. In the case of exemplification, the challenges of identifying local grammar terminologies were concerned with those which seemingly semantically overlap, such as 'Exemplification' and 'Supporting statement', 'Indicator' and 'Exemplifying'. Identification of these elements required more careful interpretation of the context and usually long discussion of the labeling. Take 'Exemplification' and 'Supporting statement' for example. The former relates to the concrete information being used to exemplify, while the latter is concerned with providing additional information, as in Examples 1 and 2.

Ex. 1 For instance, **modern-day English and modern-day German are historically related languages**.

Ex. 2 Robson's section on interviewing, for example, **is dominated by checklists.**

As shown in the two examples, both modern-day English and modern-day German … in Example 1 and is dominated by checklists in Example 2 seem to refer to the specific content of exemplification. At the first sight, students argued for no semantic distinction between the two and that the terminology 'Exemplification' would work for both. The teacher's

Table 3
Local grammar terminologies for analyzing exemplification (adapted from Su & Zhang, 2020).

Terminology	Explanation	Example
Exemplified	The thing being illustrated or clarified.	Examples below illustrate **heavy use of nominal modification in the university textbook**.
Exemplification	The element that illustrates or clarifies the Exemplified.	**The activity** is also an example of a team (or joint) activity …
Exemplifying	The lexical item that indicates the act of exemplifying being performed.	Fig. 1 **illustrates** the normal airway structure down to …
Indicator	The item that signals the act of exemplifying.	I had played multiple roles (**e.g.**, a researcher, teacher, elder sister) in a variety of settings …
Relevant study	Existing studies that are used to exemplify.	For example, Magen (1997) analyzed [bVbbVb] sequences produced by four English speakers …
Initiator	Elements that initiate the act of exemplifying.	Data were analyzed qualitatively (**see**, for example, Newby, 2010, pp. 459–460) …
Researcher	The actor who performs the act of exemplifying.	**We** can illustrate the above with the English passive.
Supporting statement	Elements that provide additional information to illustrate the Exemplified.	Potter and Hepburn (2005: 281), for example, **provide a strong argument that …**
Hinge	Elements that serve to link different parts.	An example of context **is** an agent providing a description for an item …

explanation was that modern-day English and modern-day German … in Example 1 forms the core content being illustrated. However, in Example 2, the major content being illustrated is Robson's section on interviewing, while is dominated by checklists only provides further explanation of the previous content. This indicates that it is reasonable to highlight this difference by labeling modern-day English and modern-day German … in Example 1 as 'Exemplification' whereas is dominated by checklists in Example 2 as 'Supporting statement'. All terminologies were discussed in detail until an agreement was reached.

2.6. Step 3: Identifying local grammar patterns

2.6.1. Teaching content

Based on the terminologies identified in step 2, the teacher instructed students to analyze exemplifying language from a local grammar perspective, which involved the mapping of functional terminologies on to structural elements. As shown in the sample analysis presented in Table 4, the initial clause or noun phrase, which indicates the viewpoint or argument being exemplified, was labelled 'Exemplified'. The subsequent For example or e.g., which marks the exemplifying act, was labelled 'Indicator'. And the following clause or nouns, which indicates the detailed content of explanation, was labelled 'Exemplification'. Accordingly, such instances realize the local grammar pattern of 'Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification' (see Su and Zhang (2020) for more analyses).

To inform students of the typicality of each pattern, the frequency of each pattern was also given. For example, students were informed that 'Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification' has an occurrence of 2544 times, ranking the first in our corpus (see also Su & Zhang, 2020).

2.6.2. Students' reaction and teacher's response

This step went surprisingly smooth, with only one question "How can we memorize these sequences of meanings?" raised by several students during the teaching. It was observed that students were rather interested in the less frequently used local grammar patterns such as 'Researcher + Exemplifying + Exemplified' (e.g. I exemplify how semiogenesis data can also be gathered in graduate courses …), and 'Indicator + Exemplified + Hinge + Exemplification' (e.g. An instance of this can be seen in Example 2). They were found to have a stronger desire for a larger variety of linguistic means for exemplification instead of a heavy reliance on the more frequently used expressions. The teacher dealt with this through a full explanation of all the identified local grammar patterns. Students were also told that, although the more frequently used local grammar patterns represent the typical ways in which exemplification is realized, the other infrequent patterns merit attention as well.

2.7. Step 4: Practicing contextual use of local grammar patterns

2.7.1. Teaching content

In the final step we provided students with more exercises to perform the act of exemplifying, the key to which lies in the selection of an appropriate local grammar pattern for a particular communicative task. The instances in the exercises were taken from our corpus to ensure the authenticity of the teaching material. One example of such exercises is given below.

Exercise 1 Fill in the blank with a contextually appropriate exemplifying expression.

Learners were considered as intermediate according to their scores on a four-skill language placement test administered by the program and also the level of the courses in which they had enrolled. They came from different language backgrounds _____ and were studying in the program for periods of 3–8 months.

Original text: e.g., Chinese, French, Japanese, Korean, Portuguese, Spanish, and Thai

As shown in Exercise 1, to complete this task, students needed to read through the text so as to understand it fully. The teacher also guided them to infer the structural pattern and the corresponding local grammar pattern of the exemplifying expression. It was explained that as the given initial part of the expression is a noun phrase different language backgrounds, **N such as/e.g. N** might be the structural pattern of this instance, which corresponds to the local grammar pattern of 'Exemplified + Indicator + Exemplification'. Students were thus able to infer that the blank might best be filled in with such as or e.g. which realizes 'Indicator' and the names of different languages which realize 'Exemplification'. The original text was then given to help students check their choices.

Table 4
Local grammar analysis.

Frequency	Exemplified	Indicator	Exemplification
= 2544	**Clause**	**For example,**	**Clause**
	These manifest themselves in different ways depending on the language the children are acquiring.	For example,	English children with SLI have more problems in the verbal domain
	N	**e.g.**	**N**
	Incongruent objective modulation of adjectives	(e.g.	necessary, compulsory, obligatory, important, essential, etc.)

2.7.2. Students' reaction and teacher's response

Compared with the other three steps, step 4 requires a deep context reading for a clear identification of the specific meanings in the exemplifying expression, which thus was quite time-consuming. Due to the lack of background information of the context, students had difficulties identifying the meanings of specific structural elements. For this reason, the teacher provided guidance to facilitate the form-meaning mapping process. For example, the noun phrase different language backgrounds in Exercise 1 was explained by the teacher to be general in meaning or as a superordinate category, pointing to a variety of languages spoken in different countries. Thus, it is reasonable to label the phrase as 'Exemplified'. This in turn helped students to infer the meanings of other components of this instance.

These four steps, as demonstrated above, constitute the whole process of applying a local grammar approach to teach discourse acts in EAP contexts. This design is characterized by 1) an exclusive concern over the lexical-grammatical resources that are available for performing a particular discourse act, 2) a systematic description of the semantic regularities of the lexical-grammatical resources realizing the target discourse act, and 3) an emphasis on the contextual use of the discourse act. All these helped students to better understand how to perform specific discourse acts in academic writing. Finally, it is worth noting that, while our discussion focuses on exemplification, the teaching process outlined above can by extension be applied to the teaching of various discourse acts in academic writing (e.g. definition, evaluation), thereby offering an approach that can be potentially useful for EAP teaching in general.

3. Conclusion

This study has reported on an instructional practice to explore the pedagogical applications of local grammars in EAP teaching, focusing specifically on teaching EFL learners to perform particular discourse acts in academic writing. It has outlined a teaching procedure to show how local grammars can be applied in EAP classrooms, which can be extended to the teaching of various discourse acts that are frequently performed in academic writing. Overall, our teaching practice suggests that the local grammar approach is useful for EAP pedagogy.

The present study has some limitations, however. First, it has only investigated the particular discourse act of exemplification in the discipline of Linguistics. While we argued that the proposed local grammar approach can also be applied in the teaching of other discourse acts in academic writing, its applicability needs to be further tested by examining its usefulness in pedagogical practices, especially to EFL students of different disciplinary backgrounds. More importantly, the effect of the teaching practice is not clear. Hence, it is necessary to further explore the extent to which the proposed approach is effective in EAP teaching. Finally, we have not discussed how local grammars can be integrated into the current EAP curriculum and teaching materials. All these are directions worthy of future investigation. We believe investigations into these aspects will contribute substantially to EAP pedagogy.

Author statement

The paper has not been submitted for publication, nor any part of the content has been published, in other journals.

Funding

This study is funded by Humanity and Social Science Youth Foundation of Ministry of Education of China (19YJC740030), and the teaching research project of Anhui University of Finance and Economics (Grant No. ACJYYB2019046).

Declaration of competing interest

None.

References

Hinkel, E. (2004). *Teaching academic ESL writing*. Mahwah, NJ: Lawrence Erlbaum Associates.

Hunston, S. (2002). Pattern grammar, language teaching, and linguistic variation: Applications of a corpus-driven grammar. In R. Reppen, S. M. Fitzmaurice, & D. Biber (Eds.), *Using Corpora to explore linguistic Variation* (pp. 167–183). Amsterdam: John Benjamins.

Hunston, S., & Sinclair, J. (2000). A local grammar of evaluation. In S. Hunston, & G. Thompson (Eds.), *Evaluation in text: Authorial stance and the construction of discourse* (pp. 74–101). New York: Oxford University Press.

Hunston, S., & Su, H. (2019). Patterns, constructions, and local grammar: A case study of 'evaluation'. *Applied Linguistics, 40*(4), 567–593.

Hyland, K. (2007). Applying a gloss: Exemplifying and reformulating in academic discourse. *Applied Linguistics, 28*(2), 266–285.

Limberg, H. (2015). Principles for pragmatics teaching: Apologies in the EFL classroom. *ELT Journal, 69*(3), 275–285.

Lu, X., Yoon, J., & Kisselev, O. (2021). Matching phrase-frames to rhetorical moves in social science research article introductions. *English for Specific Purposes, 61*, 63–83.

Moreno, A., & Swales, J. M. (2018). Strengthening move analysis methodology towards bridging the function-form gap. *English for Specific Purposes, 50*, 40–63.

Su, H. (2020). Patterns, local grammars and the design of English teaching materials. *ELT Journal, 74*(1), 73–82.

Su, H., & Zhang, L. (2020). Local grammars and discourse acts in academic writing: A case study of exemplification in linguistics research articles. *Journal of English for Academic Purposes, 43*, 1–11.

Lei Zhang is an associate professor at Anhui University of Finance and Economics, China. His research interests mainly are corpus linguistics and English language teaching. He has published an article in *Journal of English for Academic Purposes* and several articles in Chinese journals. **Email:** zhangleiaufe@126.com

Hang Su is a professor of English language and linguistics at Sichuan International Studies University. His research interests include corpus linguistics, pragmatics, and English language teaching. He has published in journals such as *Applied Linguistics*, *ELT Journal*, *Journal of English for Academic Purposes*, among many others. **Email:** suhangunique@hotmail.com